

MINDCRAFT

Brand Book

Version 1.1 · The Desk by MindCraft

Math is the mechanism. The story is the point.
The Desk is the place. Everything serves the click.

Voice · Maya · vocabulary · visual stages · anti-positioning · research handshake

~4,567 words · confidential · share with partners as needed

joinmindcraft.com

Product name on the web: **The Desk by MindCraft**. App chrome / home screen: **The Desk**.

Pedagogy translation of research: docs/canon/PEDAGOGY.md · Research OS: agent_work/research/ (Constitution v1.16).

Shareable PDF: regenerate with python3 docs/canon/generate_brand_book.py → BRAND_BOOK.pdf.

This document governs every design, copy, product, and marketing decision at MindCraft. When two options conflict, this book breaks the tie. When the book itself is unclear, the Brand Essence breaks the tie. Read it before you write a headline, pick a color, name a feature, or ship a screen. Agents: start at docs/canon/README.md.

0. Naming (binding)

Surface	Say
Company / publisher	MindCraft
Marketing product	The Desk by MindCraft
App home screen + in-app chrome	The Desk (text only — no MindCraft / raccoon logo mark in chrome)
Narrative layer	Katha
Student sections	Notes · Solver · Map

Never call the student app “MindCraftNotes” in user-facing copy. Internal Xcode target names may lag; display name is **The Desk**.

1. Brand Essence

The Desk by MindCraft gives the student who gave up on math the click: the felt experience of being good, inside a story where being good matters.

Every decision either serves the click or gets out of its way. Math is the mechanism. The story is the point. The Desk is the place she works; MindCraft is the company that built it.

2. Manifesto

Somebody decided you were not a math person. Maybe a teacher said it with a red pen. Maybe a test said it with a number. Maybe you said it yourself, quietly, in eighth grade, and nobody argued.

They described a moment. You heard a verdict.

Here is what actually happened: the story lost you. One day the symbols stopped meaning anything, the class kept moving, and pretending became easier than asking. That is not a broken brain. That is a broken narrative.

MindCraft rebuilds the narrative. Every concept you missed is a scene you have not played yet. Every gap has a shape. The engine finds it, and the story walks you back to the exact place where math lost you. Then it hands you a problem that matters, inside a world where solving it changes something.

And then it happens. The pattern surfaces. The fog burns off. You feel the click, the specific high of suddenly seeing it, and you finally know what the kids in the front row have been feeling all along.

You were never bad at math. You were waiting for a better story.

This is it.

3. Mission

Turn every student who gave up on math into someone who has felt what it is like to be good at it.

4. Vision

A living world (and a daily OS — **The Desk**) where the student is the character, every math problem is a mission, mastery visibly changes the map, and a human tutor walks in already knowing the gap. Full horizon map: `WORLD_VISION.md`. Research thesis under audit: identity transformation, not mathematics delivery (`agent_work/research/`).

5. The Student

Her name is Maya. She is sixteen, a junior, and she takes the ACT in April.

She is not failing math. That is the part everyone gets wrong. She holds a B minus by memorizing procedures the night before tests and forgetting them by Friday. She writes strong history essays. Her English teacher reads her paragraphs out loud to the class. In seventh grade she switched schools mid-year, landed in a class three weeks deep into fractions, and never caught up. A teacher, meaning to comfort her, said "some people are just more verbal." Maya heard it as a diagnosis. She has been living inside it for four years.

Here is Maya at 2am, six days before the ACT. A practice test glows on her laptop. She has read question 14 five times. Each read, the symbols dissolve a little more. She switches tabs, watches a video about a topic she already understands, because understanding something, anything, quiets the chest-tightness for a minute. She is not lazy. She is rationing shame. Every problem she attempts and misses confirms the verdict, so she has learned to stop attempting. Giving up is not her weakness. Giving up is her armor.

What she tells people: "I don't really care about math. I'm more of a words person."

What she never tells anyone: she watches the front-row kids finish early and wants, more than almost anything, to know what that feels like from the inside. Not the grade. The feeling. She wants to be the one somebody turns to and asks, "wait, how did you do that?" She has rehearsed explaining things she does not yet understand.

What earns her trust: being taken seriously. Real stakes. Plain language about exactly where her gaps are, delivered without a verdict attached. A hard problem given to her like she can handle it, because she can.

What loses her in three seconds: cartoon mascots. "Math is fun!" Confetti for trivial things. Anything that smells remedial. Being told to try again on the same problem, as if her attempt were a coin flip that might land differently this time.

Maya does not need motivation. She needs one honest click, and then she will supply her own.

6. The Tutor

His name is Jordan. He is twenty, a sophomore studying engineering, and he remembers his own click with photographic precision: eleventh grade, a physics TA, a spring problem that suddenly became a picture instead of a formula. He has been chasing the chance to hand that moment to someone else ever since.

He tutors partly for money and mostly because explaining things is the best version of himself. His frustration is structural, not personal: he spends the first forty minutes of every session playing detective, poking at problems, guessing where the real gap hides, and by the time he finds it the hour is gone. Worse, his students have learned to perform understanding. They nod at the right moments to end the session politely. He can feel it happening and cannot always stop it.

What MindCraft gives him: the map, already drawn. The engine walks in knowing that Maya's quadratics problem is actually a slopes problem from three concepts back. Jordan's hour goes to the human part: the analogy, the patience, the eye contact when the click lands.

How the brand treats him: as a co-author, never as gig labor. He is the person who carries the flame across the table. Copy aimed at tutors runs peer-level and technical. It never says "learners." It never says "leverage outcomes." It says: here is exactly where your student is stuck, here is why, go do the thing you are great at.

7. Brand Personality

Five adjectives. Every piece of MindCraft output should score on at least three.

1. Cinematic.

MindCraft frames everything as a scene with stakes, never as a curriculum unit. If a screen could open a film, it belongs; if it could open a textbook chapter, it does not.

Sounds like: "The flood is three days out and the fields are still unmarked."

Never sounds like: "Welcome to Module 4: Introduction to Fractions."

2. Electric.

The brand chases the click, so its energy is sharp, sudden, and earned rather than constant and cheap. Excitement that fires at everything means nothing; MindCraft saves the voltage for the moment it matters.

Sounds like: "There it is."

Never sounds like: "Great job!!! Keep up the amazing work!"

3. Certain.

MindCraft speaks in declaratives because the engine actually knows things and the story actually goes somewhere. Hedging tells an already-doubtful student that even the software doubts them.

Sounds like: "You can learn this. The map says so."

Never sounds like: "You might want to consider possibly reviewing some earlier topics."

4. Human.

The brand knows exactly what 2am feels like and never pretends otherwise, but warmth here means respect, not babying. It talks to Maya like the capable person she is about to discover she is.

Sounds like: "That gap has been sitting there since seventh grade. It ends today."

Never sounds like: "Don't worry! Math is super hard for everyone!"

5. Unflinching.

MindCraft names gaps plainly, keeps the stakes real, and refuses both sugarcoating and shame. Honesty without a verdict is the whole trick: the gap is a fact about the map, never a fact about the person.

Sounds like: "Slopes are your weak point right now. Here is the way through."

Never sounds like: "Oopsie! Let's give that another whirl!"

8. Voice and Tone

One voice, six dials. The voice never changes; the tone adjusts to what the student is feeling in that moment.

Universal voice rules:

- Second person. Present tense. Active voice.
- Verbs first. Short sentences. Declaratives.
- Stakes before instructions.
- Sentence case everywhere. No exclamation marks in UI chrome. No emoji in product copy, ever.
- The word "yet" is sacred. "You can't do this" never ships. "You can't do this yet" barely ships. "You haven't done this yet" ships.
- Never blame the student. Never baby the student. The distance between those two is where MindCraft lives.

UI microcopy

Compressed, kinetic, six words or fewer. Buttons are actions in a story, not functions in software.

- Start button: **Run the mission**

- Diagnostic entry: **Start the gap scan**
- Continue: **Next move**
- Knowledge graph: **Open the map**
- Session end: **That's the run. See what changed.**

Story splash text

This is Katha's territory (see Section 10). Present tense, sensory, a human in a crisis whose shape is the math. Roughly 200 words, ending on the problem itself. The math is never announced; it surfaces.

Example opening: "Kai has been awake for thirty hours. The playtest is at noon, and the character still jumps wrong: too high off the ledge, too flat off the ramp, like the world's gravity changes its mind. Somewhere in the jump code, one relationship is lying."

Error states (technical failures)

Calm, honest, ownership taken by the system. The student never wonders if they broke something, because they didn't.

- Connection loss: **"The connection dropped. We saved your progress. Reconnecting now."**
- Load failure: **"That didn't load. It's on us. Give it a second and pull the map again."**
- Never: "Oops!", "Uh-oh!", "Something went wrong :(", or any error that performs cuteness.

Success states

Understated and electric. The click needs no cheerleading; it needs acknowledgment. The bigger the moment, the fewer the words.

- Correct in practice: **"There it is."**
- Concept mastered: **"Mastered. The map just changed."**
- Gap closed: **"That gap held you for two years. It's gone."**
- Never: confetti language, "Awesome!", "You're a rockstar," streak-guilt framing.

Marketing headlines

Big claims stated flatly, aimed at the verdict Maya carries. Every headline should make the kid who gave up stop scrolling. Product line when naming the app: **The Desk by MindCraft.**

- **You were never bad at math.**
- **Feel what it's like to be good.**
- **Math didn't lose you. The story did.**
- **The kids in the front row aren't smarter. They just clicked earlier.**
- **The Desk by MindCraft — learning that learns you.**

Claims we will not make (research-aligned)

Defendable claims only — see Pedagogy Canon + Constitution kills:

- No ACT / score **point guarantees.**
- No streak / XP / leaderboard as proof of mastery.

- No “AI replaces tutors” or “tutoring is free.”
- No item-count or “complete ACT bank” hero without coverage honesty.
- No Identity / Belief / Anxiety Score™ theater in parent or student copy.

Email subject lines

Sentence case, specific, story-forward. No fake urgency, no "Don't miss out," no discount energy.

- **Your map changed overnight**
- **One gap left in linear equations**
- **Kai's game still crashes. The function is waiting.**
- **Six days to the ACT. Here's your actual weak point.**

Tone dials by context

Context	What the student feels	Tone dial
Gap scan	Exposed, braced for judgment	Steady, factual, zero verdicts
Story splash	Curious, guard lowered	Full cinematic, immersive
Mid-practice miss	Old shame flickering	Direct, forward-pointing, brief
Mastery moment	The click	Electric, spare, let it land
Marketing	Skeptical, burned before	Certain, unflinching, bold
Tutor-facing	Professional, invested	Peer-level, precise, warm

9. Visual Identity

Two stages, one brand:

1. **Story / marketing / Katha** — film title sequence energy: Deep Field, enormous type, high contrast. Never looks like a school LMS.
2. **The Desk OS** (Jesse’s Kitchen, Work, Create) — cream paper workspace, soft ink (#143a2e), lime accents. Feels like a real desk she owns, not a dark theater. Do not force Deep Field onto The Desk surfaces.

Color system

Color	Hex	Name	Role
Near-black	#080e14	Deep Field	Marketing, story, Katha, cinematic moments.
Desk paper	#f7f5f0 / #f8faf7	Field Desk cream	The Desk OS canvas (Work / Create / kitchen chrome).
Ink green	#143a2e	Desk ink	Primary text on cream Desk surfaces.

White / chalk	#f5f5f5	Chalk	Primary text on Deep Field.
Lime	#c4f547	The Click	Mastery, primary CTAs, earned signal.
Red	#c1121f	Stakes	Narrative tension, gap severity, Katha's flame — never student shame.
Navy	#1d3a8a	Depth	Graph edges / secondary structure on dark stages.

Usage rules:

- **Stage-appropriate canvas.** Deep Field for story and marketing. Cream for The Desk OS. Do not mix randomly on one screen.
- **The Click is earned.** Lime means something just happened or is about to. Never two competing lime CTAs.
- **Stakes belongs to the story, never to the student.** Red never marks a miss as “you failed.” A red X on student work is banned.
- **Desk chrome stays calm.** Top-left product mark is the words **The Desk** — no raccoon / Minecraft logo in app chrome (logo stays for marketing site / company mark).

Typography direction

No specific typefaces mandated. The feelings are mandated.

- **Display (Minecraft voice):** a confident geometric grotesque with tight tracking and real presence at poster scale. It should feel like a title card, an athletic brand, a launch countdown. Set it huge: the type scale jumps hard, display sizes at four times body or more, so every screen has one loud statement and quiet everything else.
- **UI text:** a clean humanist sans built for legibility at small sizes, with tabular numerals wherever the engine reports data (mastery, timing, counts). The engine's numbers should feel machined.
- **Story text (Katha voice):** an editorial serif with genuine literary character, the kind of face you'd find in a novel, not a textbook. When the serif appears, the reader knows without being told: the storyteller is speaking now.
- **Never:** rounded "friendly" fonts, handwriting fonts, anything that signals children's education, chalkboard textures, comic-adjacent anything.

Imagery direction

Belongs:

- Cinematic scenes from the stories: the game studio at 2am lit by one monitor, the Nile at flood under a red dawn, rendered like film stills with a single dominant light source.
- The knowledge graph as an object of beauty: constellation-like node fields on Deep Field, navy edges, lime nodes where mastery lives, red where gaps burn.
- Bold geometric abstraction with narrative weight: a parabola as the arc of a jump, a slope as a rising floodline. Math as scenery, not decoration.
- Darkness with a point of light. This is the brand's core image: the click, visualized.

Never belongs:

- Stock photos of any kind. Especially smiling students at laptops.
- Chat bubbles, robot mascots, anthropomorphized anything.
- Clip-art math: floating pi symbols, raining numbers, cartoon calculators.
- Trophies, gold stars, badge-cabinet iconography.
- Anything a school would laminate.

Motion principles

1. **Motion means state change.** Things move because the world changed: a node lights, an edge strengthens, a path redraws. Nothing animates to seem lively.
 2. **Weight over bounce.** Elements move with mass and settle with intent. Nothing springs, jiggles, or celebrates cutely.
 3. **The click gets the budget.** Mastery moments earn the largest, slowest, most considered animation in the product: the node ignites, the map ripples, up to 800ms. Routine UI stays fast and invisible, 150 to 250ms.
 4. **Nothing begs.** No idle loops, no wiggling buttons, no notification-dot anxiety mechanics. The world waits with dignity.
 5. **Dark stays dark.** Transitions move through Deep Field, never through white flashes.
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10. The Katha Sub-brand

Katha (Sanskrit: story) is the narrative layer of MindCraft. It is a sub-brand with its own voice, its own typography, and its own mark, living entirely inside MindCraft.

The division of labor

MindCraft is the system. Katha is the fire.

MindCraft measures, maps, diagnoses, and builds: the engine, the knowledge graph, the gap scan, the mastery model. It speaks in the geometric sans, signals in lime and navy, and deals in facts about the map.

Katha tells the story: every splash, every scene, every mission frame. It speaks in the editorial serif, burns in red and chalk, and deals in humans in trouble. Kai's broken jump. The scribe watching the flood erase the field lines.

The handoff is a designed moment. The engine decides *what* Maya needs (that is MindCraft's job, deterministic and auditable) and then the flame appears, the serif takes over, and Katha gives her a *reason* (that is Katha's job, and the engine never writes a word of it). One brand does the math about the math. The other makes it matter.

How Katha sounds

- Present tense, sensory, specific. Always a person, always a crisis, always stakes.
- Katha never mentions the interface. It does not say "concept," "practice," "mastery," "level," "question," or "click here." The moment story text acknowledges the software, the spell breaks.
- Katha never explains the math. It arranges the crisis so the math is the only door out, then steps aside.
- Katha ends every story at the threshold of the problem, never past it. The student, not the narrator, opens the door.

How Katha looks

- Editorial serif on Deep Field. Generous margins and negative space, like the page of a novel printed on darkness.
- Red and chalk are Katha's colors. Lime almost never appears in Katha's frame: lime belongs to the engine, and the click happens after the story, not inside it.
- Illustrated or rendered scenes composed like film stills: one light source, one figure, one problem in the air.
- Every story signs itself: a small flame mark and the words **A Katha story**.

The flame

The flame mark carries three meanings, in order:

1. **Stories began around fire.** Katha is the oldest technology for making knowledge survivable: wrap it in a narrative and pass it around the flame. The mark claims that lineage.
2. **The click is a strike of light in the dark.** The whole visual system is darkness waiting for ignition. The flame is the promise that ignition comes.
3. **Fire is carried.** Tutor to student, story to student, student to the next student who gave up. Nobody keeps the flame. Everybody hands it on.

Flame rules: the flame appears whenever Katha speaks and nowhere else. Red on Deep Field. Never a mascot, never given a face, never animated in idle loops. It may flare once, briefly, at a mastery moment: the story's stakes resolving into the engine's light.

11. Vocabulary

Words build the world. These pairs are binding for all product copy, marketing, and support.

We say	We never say	Why
challenge	quiz	A quiz judges you at school. A challenge invites you into a story. "Quiz" is banned outright.
weakness (with care)	deficiency, deficit	"Weakness" is honest and useful when it describes the map, spoken privately, attached to a concept. It never describes the person.
not yet / not this one	wrong	"Wrong" is a verdict on the person. "Not yet" is a fact about time.
not yet / not this one	incorrect	"Incorrect" is "wrong" wearing a lab coat. Same verdict, colder delivery.

look at [the specific thing], then take the next one	try again	"Try again" asks the student to repeat a failure with no new information. MindCraft always points at what to see differently first.
mission	assignment, homework	Assignments come from authority. Missions come from stakes.
story	content	"Content" is what gets poured into feeds. Nobody ever changed their life because of content.
the click	aha moment, lightbulb moment	The click is the brand's own word for its own promise. Greeting-card synonyms dilute it.
gap	falling behind	A gap is a location on a map: findable, closeable, gone when closed. "Behind" is a race the student already believes they lost.
practice	drill	Drilling is what happens to teeth and soldiers. Practice is what musicians and athletes do on purpose.
master	complete, finish	You complete a form. You master a skill. Concepts are never "done"; they are owned.
you / player	user	Users consume software. Players inhabit worlds. In student-facing copy, just say "you."
world / map	app, platform	Student-facing copy never names the software category. The product is a place, not a program.
gap scan	diagnostic test, placement test	Both banned terms contain "test," and "test" is the exact machine that issued Maya's verdict. A scan finds things; a test judges people.
yet	can't (unqualified)	"Yet" is the single most important word in the vocabulary. Every statement of inability carries it or dies in review.

sharp, locked in	smart, dumb	Intelligence-as-identity language is banned in both directions. Praise the seeing, never the ceiling.
quick / short	easy	Calling a problem "easy" sets a trap: miss it and the verdict returns doubled. Describe length, never difficulty-as-judgment.
tutor	instructor, coach, mentor (in product)	One name for the human across the table.
story-driven	gamified	"Gamified" means points bolted onto boredom. The story is load-bearing. Banned even in internal decks.
earn / unlock	reward	Rewards are pellets from a dispenser. Earning and unlocking are things that happen inside a world because you changed it.

12. Anti-positioning

What MindCraft is explicitly not, and why each comparison fails on contact.

Not Khan Academy. A library assumes you walked in wanting a book; MindCraft exists for the student who stopped walking in. Khan organizes the world's math superbly for the already-motivated, while MindCraft manufactures the motivation itself, which is the actual missing ingredient for the kid who gave up.

Not Duolingo. Duolingo made the mechanic the point: streaks, guilt, an owl trained to make you open an app, with the content as filler between dopamine hits. MindCraft inverts it: the story is the point and math is the mechanism, because streak anxiety teaches you to launch software, and it has never once taught anyone to see a pattern.

Not a tutoring app. Tutoring marketplaces sell hours and pray that chemistry happens inside them; MindCraft sells the click and uses the engine to make the human hour count, because the tutor should spend forty minutes teaching, not forty minutes guessing where the gap is.

Not a homework helper. Homework helpers optimize for tonight: answer delivered, dependence deepened, gap untouched and compounding. MindCraft optimizes for the version of you that stops needing help, and any feature that hands out answers without building the seeing has failed the brand test by definition.

13. Brand Story

MindCraft started at a tutoring table, watching the same scene repeat. A student flinches at a worksheet. The same student, twenty minutes later, leans all the way in because the problem became a person: a game developer whose

character jumps at the wrong height, a scribe watching the flood erase every boundary in the valley. Same math. Different story. Completely different kid.

The founders kept pulling on that thread and found two separable problems. Finding the gap is a systems problem: it takes a knowledge graph, real evidence, and a deterministic engine that never guesses. Caring about the gap is a story problem: it takes stakes, a character, a world that answers back. Every product on the market solved one and ignored the other.

So MindCraft builds both, welded together: an engine that knows exactly where math lost you, and a storyteller that gives you a reason to go back for it.

14. Application Examples

Six real contexts, final copy quality. This is what the brand sounds like in the wild.

Push notification (re-engagement, student mid-story on functions):

Kai's game still crashes at the jump. The function is waiting.

Story splash opening line (fractions, the Nile scribe):

The flood took the field markers in the night, and by morning forty farmers stand at the water's edge, each one certain his land was bigger than this.

Wrong-answer feedback message (practice, linear equations):

Not this one. The slope tells you how fast it changes, not where it starts. Take the next one with that in your pocket.

Dashboard headline (returning student, one gap from a milestone):

One gap stands between you and quadratics. It's the same one from seventh grade. Today's the day.

Marketing site hero headline:

You were never bad at math.

Subhead: Somebody told you that, and you built a life around it. The Desk by MindCraft finds the exact moment math lost you, then tells the story that brings you back.

App Store description, opening lines:

The Desk by MindCraft is where you find out you were never bad at math.

>

A learning engine maps exactly where math lost you: not the chapter, the concept, the precise gap. Then a story world gives you a reason to go back for it. Every concept is a scene. Every problem is a mission. And somewhere in your first week, it happens: the pattern surfaces, the fog burns off, and you feel the click the front-row kids have been feeling all along.

15. Research handshake

Brand copy must stay inside what pedagogy can defend. When research kills a Score™ or packaging claim, Brand Book follows — we do not keep the pretty lie.

Topic	Look first
What to build / measure	docs/canon/PEDAGOGY.md
Evidence + Red Team	agent_work/research/MINDCRAFT_RESEARCH_CONSTITUTION_v1.md
Why / horizons	WORLD_VISION.md
Agent index	docs/canon/README.md

End of Brand Book v1.1. When in doubt, reread the essence: math is the mechanism, the story is the point, The Desk is the place, and everything serves the click.